

Searzo AI VISIBILITY

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AI VISIBILITY TEARDOWN

Accountalent keeps the books for **LangChain** and **Retool**. ChatGPT has never heard .

A forensic look at why a firm trusted by 7,500+ startups is invisible the moment a founder asks an AI assistant who to hire — and the precise, fixable reasons why.

SUBJECT

Accountalent · est.
2009 · Boston

ENGINES

ChatGPT · **Perplexity** ·
Gemini · AI Overviews

STATUS

Public · independently
verifiable

ISSUED

MAY 2026 · sample

FINDING OF FACT // A STRONG FIRM THE MACHINES CAN'T SEE

A founder's shortlist firm, missing from the *machine's*.

Accountalent is not a weak business. It has served 7,500+ startups since 2009, counts LangChain, Retool, Ghost, Casper and Outreach among its clients, was founded by a CPA who mentors at the Harvard i-Lab, and prices below most competitors. By every human measure, it belongs on a founder's shortlist.

Yet ask an AI assistant "best accounting firm for a SaaS startup" or "who handles R&D tax credits for startups," and the same handful of names return – Pilot, Kruze, indinero, Fondo, Zeni. Accountalent does not appear. The cause isn't reputation. The firm is **structurally unreadable** to the systems now making the recommendation.

EXHIBIT · PRESENCE IN THE EDITORIAL "BEST STARTUP ACCOUNTANT" LISTS AI MODELS LEARN FROM

Pilot IN NEARLY EVERY LIST		≈ 9/10
Kruze Consulting IN NEARLY EVERY LIST		≈ 9/10
indinero · Fondo · Zeni FREQUENT		≈ 5-6/10
Accountalent OWN PR & DIRECTORIES ONLY		≈ 0/10

FIELD TEST · 60 SECONDS

Open ChatGPT or Perplexity and ask "best R&D tax credit firm for startups." Count the mentions of Accountalent – a firm whose entire R&D practice unlocks up to \$500K/yr in credits. Then ask the same about Fondo. The gap isn't quality. It's visibility engineering.

"Editorial lists" = the third-party "best startup accounting firm" round-ups (Zeni, Clutch, CoCountant, Anomaly, South, Sound Advice et al., 2025-26) that AI engines treat as trusted sources. Counts are approximate, drawn from the public lists reviewed for this sample; a paid engagement replaces them with a live, multi-run query measurement across engines.

MOTIVE // AI IS NOW THE LAYER WHERE REFERRALS GET CHECKED

The lost referral.

Accounting is a referral business — and that's exactly why this matters. The danger isn't only the lead you never see. It's the one you already earned, quietly lost at the last step.

THE SEQUENCE PLAYING OUT RIGHT NOW

A board member recommends the firm for an R&D study. The CFO writes the name down — then, before reaching out, opens ChatGPT: "best firm for startup R&D tax credits?" The firm has done this work for fifteen years. **Its name doesn't appear.** The CFO books the firm the machine named instead.

This is no longer the exception. Buyers now treat AI as a **verification layer** over every referral — and a firm that's invisible there loses deals it had already won by reputation.

THE EVIDENCE · INDEPENDENT SURVEYS, NOT VENDOR CLAIMS

94%	of B2B buyers now use AI in the purchase process	Up from 89% a year earlier. Forrester's 2026 survey of ~18,000 global buyers — who named generative AI a more meaningful research source than vendor sites, experts or sales reps. [Forrester, Jan 2026]
51%	start research with an AI chatbot more often than Google	And 71% use AI somewhere in the process — with vendor strength/weakness comparison the #1 use case. [G2, survey of 1,076 buyers, Mar 2026]
3×	conversion rate of AI-referred clients vs. site average — at a real firm	Top-25 firm Withum reports AI-sourced web leads convert at triple its site average, with ChatGPT the largest single referrer. [Accounting Today, Nov 2025]

THE HONEST READ

For a single firm the volume of net-new AI leads is still modest today — we won't pretend otherwise. The point isn't a flood of new leads. It's that the **verification step already exists**, it's growing fast, and being absent there quietly forfeits referrals the firm already earned. Cheap to fix now; expensive to ignore.

Sources as labeled: Forrester 2026 Buyers' Journey Survey; G2 2026 AI Search Insight Report (n=1,076 B2B software buyers); Accounting Today, "AI a growing source of new client referrals," Nov 2025. Figures quoted from published summaries; full citations available on request.

EXHIBITS A-D // EVERY REASON IS FIXABLE

Four reasons the firm is *invisible*.

Drawn from the live public site. None of this is about spending more — it's about making strengths the firm already has machine-readable.

EXHIBIT A

01

The best proof is locked inside images

The homepage shows a wall of marquee client logos — LangChain, Retool, Ghost, Casper, Outreach, Veho. To a founder, the most persuasive thing on the page. To an AI crawler, nothing: each is an SVG image with no text and no alt attribute. The very fact that would make an AI recommend them is unreadable by the machine.

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WHAT THE AI CRAWLER ACTUALLY READS:  
    →  
no extractable client names
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EXHIBIT B

02

No content aimed at how buyers actually ask

Their "Resources" publish genuine thought-leadership — but on topics like how the Catholic Church is funded and the LinkedIn equity story. There is no page answering what a founder types into an AI: "best accountant for a YC startup," "Accountalent vs Pilot," "who maximizes startup R&D credits." When the AI seeks a source to cite on those queries, the firm offers nothing that matches.

EXHIBIT C

03

Sharp differentiators, buried in marketing prose

The firm's strongest selling points — a fixed \$2,450/yr tax program, bookkeeping from \$199/mo, up to \$500K/yr in refundable R&D credits, no retainers — are real and competitive. But they sit inside flowing sales copy, not the structured, extractable fact-blocks an AI lifts verbatim into an answer. The facts exist; the format hides them.

EXHIBIT D

04

Thin footprint in the places AI trusts

AI engines lean on third-party signals — editorial round-ups, Reddit, Quora, niche directories. Accountalent appears almost only in its own press releases and a couple of listings. The independent "best startup accountant" lists models ingest don't mention it, so the association never forms.

Method: manual review of accountalent.com and its indexed sources, May 2026. "What the crawler reads" reflects how text-extracting AI crawlers parse image elements lacking text alternatives. A full paid audit adds a technical crawl — structured-data / schema coverage, render-blocking, crawlability — verified against each engine.

EXHIBIT E // THE SAME FIRM, MADE LEGIBLE

What "fixed" looks like.

Diagnosis is cheap. Here is the craft — a real before/after on Accountalent's own R&D copy, rebuilt so an AI can extract and cite it.

▼ BEFORE • AS PUBLISHED TODAY "Startups are eligible for up to \$500,000 in refundable R&D Tax Credits annually. Accountalent's AI-enabled software and startup-friendly prices help you maximize your refund." Reads as an ad. No question to match, no entity, no structure — the AI skims past it.	▲ AFTER • CITATION-READY Q – Which firm helps startups claim R&D tax credits? Accountalent, a startup-only CPA firm (est. 2009; 7,500+ clients incl. LangChain, Retool), runs PATH-Act R&D studies recovering up to \$500,000/yr in payroll-tax credits, fixed-fee at under half typical competitor cost. + FAQPage & Organization schema so the engine parses the entity, the claim and the proof.
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THE THREE LEVERS • IN ORDER OF IMPACT

L1	Make the proof readable	Client names, counts and credentials in text + structured data — not locked inside logos and prose.
L2	Answer the real questions	Pages and Q&A built around the recommendatory queries founders actually put to an AI.
L3	Earn external signals	Targeted presence in the round-ups, Reddit/Quora threads and directories AI engines cite — the part that can't be automated.

PRECEDENT • ALREADY PROVEN BY A DIRECT COMPETITOR

Fondo built pages engineered to answer exactly these founder questions (published at ai.fondo.com). The result: it now surfaces in AI answers far above its size. Accountalent has the **stronger client roster** — it simply isn't speaking the machines' language yet.

The "before" text is quoted from accountalent.com for analysis. The "after" is an illustrative rewrite, not published copy.
"Schema" = standard Schema.org structured data (Organization, FAQPage).

DISPOSITION // YOUR BRAND, OUR PRODUCTION LINE

This depth — for every client, *under your name.*

You already own the relationship and the retainer. We're the production layer behind the curtain: we run the teardown, do the technical and content work, and hand you a finished, branded deliverable. Your client never knows we exist.

WHAT YOU GET

- This exact depth of audit, white-labeled to your agency
- Done-for-you execution: schema, content, external signals
- Before/after Share-of-Voice reporting in your branding
- A new recurring line item — with no new hires

WHY US, NOT A DIRECT VENDOR

Vendors like Fondo's model sell straight to the accounting firm and take the client. We do the opposite — we stay invisible behind your brand and hand you the margin and the relationship. You're the one who looks ahead of the AI shift.

15 min a short call to walk your client list and pick where to start	≈1 wk turnaround on a full teardown once we agree on a target	3 mo to a measurable before/after Share-of-Voice result
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NEXT STEP · A 15-MINUTE CALL

If this lands, let's talk for fifteen minutes. We'll look at your client roster together, find the ones most exposed to the lost-referral problem, and scope what a branded engagement would look like under your name. No obligation — just a sharper read on where you stand.

Reply with a time that works, and we'll send a calendar hold.

Accountalent is used here only as a public, verifiable sample to demonstrate method; it is not a client of ours or, presumably, yours. All findings derive from the firm's public website and public search sources, May 2026, and are independently checkable. Replace this footer and the cover logo with your agency's branding before sending to a client.